

THE

ARCANE AETHER

A rules-light fantasy game about rewriting reality

RULEBOOK LAYOUT PROTOTYPE · V4.5

i About this prototype

This sample tests two-column flow, tables, callouts, headings, page breaks, and content pulled from the Obsidian vault. The source rules have not been changed.

The Arcane Aether

The Arcane Aether is a rules-light fantasy game about ordinary people who discover that reality can be rewritten. I am trying to explore two ideas with these rules:

- Can magic stay open-ended and weird while still being fun at the table?
- Can a simple system let characters progress during play, as a direct result of the choices made in a session?

It is inspired by Powered by the Apocalypse, Shadowdark, Blades in the Dark, Cairn, and other games where characters take shape through play.

I am not very concerned with encounter balance, and the game does not offer many guardrails. I want something quick to learn and quick to get into play, with room for silly, out-of-the-box ideas. I also like the thought that you can borrow magic from any other game and see what it does here.

As a GM, I like to play to find out and leave room for freeform play. I want simple monster creation and fast, fluid fights when the players decide to fight.

Where the magic items come from

Why are there so many magic items? Why do the people capable of making them keep leaving them in tombs, shops, and holes in the ground?

In this game, Arcanists make magic items because they need somewhere to put their Exposure before it changes them. They pour it into objects, use those objects for a while, and eventually have to leave some of them behind. Every relic came from someone with a problem. That was the idea I wanted to explore, and the rest of the game grew around it.

What makes it different

Magic is a conversation, not a list

There is no spell list. A player says what they want their character's magic to do and prices its reach, force, and duration. The GM confirms or adjusts the cost, then the player decides if the effect is worth the Exposure. You do not need to predict every possible spell. You just need to understand what the player is asking for and make the Exposure cost clear.

Characters advance through their choices

I want character progression to happen while everyone is playing, not as a separate downtime step or paperwork after the game. Characters gain Luck when things go badly and when they complete their goals.

Players can spend that Luck to improve their characters, help one another, or play out a flashback that changes the present. Casting can also teach new Spell Tags, but it slowly fills the character's inventory with permanent Mutations.

Monsters should be easy to run

A monster needs four numbers and answers to two questions: what does it want, and what is its weakness?

I also like using randomness when I do not already know the answer. Monster tiers are numbered 1 to 6, so you can roll a d6 and let the dice decide how dangerous the next thing is. A little randomness can push the story somewhere none of us planned.

I do not think every encounter needs to be balanced. Tell the players what their characters can see, let them decide what risks to take, and follow the consequences. The monster's Desire also leaves room for a bargain when another attack roll would be less interesting.

Example: Goblin, Tier 1 Pest

Threat: -1 | **Damage:** 1 | **Health:** 3 | **Armor:** 0 -

Attacks: Rusty knife, rocks, biting. - **Weakness:** Bright light drives them back. - **Desire:** Something shiny, and to see tomorrow.

Strange ideas are allowed to work

Not everything needs a roll. Let the silly ideas move the story. Maybe a character knows how to speak Orc because they once spent a summer in an Orc camp pretending to be a baby Orc's doll, that sounds good to me.

Character Creation

Make someone who had a life before they became an Arcanist. Three steps are enough to begin. The rest can come out during play.

Step 1: Basic details

Give your character a name and a few details: their age, appearance, voice, and where they are from. A line is plenty.

Then choose a Life Type and record both of its traits. Humans, elves, goblins, cat people, karate turtles, and stranger things all have a place in this world.

Life types

Human

- **Resilient:** Once a day, ignore one Fatigue as it would be marked.
- **I Know a Guy:** Once per session, declare that your character knows someone useful in the current location. Tell the table how they know each other.

Elf

- **Foresight:** Play one free flashback per session.
- **Old Grudge:** When old knowledge or an old event matters, your character remembers because they were there.

Goblin

- **Overlooked:** Add +1 when your character hides, squeezes, scurries, or goes unnoticed.
- **Goblin Friends:** If a goblin is involved, your character knows them. Tell the table how.

Beastfolk

Choose the animal that shapes your character.

- **Natural Weapons:** Their unarmed attacks deal 2 damage.
- **Keen Senses:** Add +1 when they use one heightened sense appropriate to that animal.

Otherfolk

Otherfolk includes people commonly thought of as monsters, such as crab people, intelligent oozes, lizard folk, vampires, or skeletons.

Choose one body advantage that fits what your character is. Describe what it lets them do.

Examples:

- A shell or thick hide gives 1 Armor.
- A lizard person may use their tail as a weapon.
- A vampire may turn into a bat.
- A skeleton may detach and reattach their limbs.

Step 2: Choose an Archetype

Your character's Archetype represents the life they led before becoming an Arcanist.

Choose one. Take its starting gear, maximum Health, and one Perk. Use its suggested Stats, or arrange **+2, +1, 0, and -1** across the four Stats yourself.

Stat	What it covers
Strength	Muscle, force, fighting hand to hand
Dexterity	Speed, stealth, precision, ranged attacks
Willpower	Endurance and resolve
Charm	Persuasion and presence

Set your character's current Health equal to their maximum Health.

Archetype	The character's old life	Maximum Health
Hunter	Tracked Arcanists for coin, then woke up as one.	7
Thief	Lived by wit, speed, and other people's things.	6
Performer	Lived by fast talk and knowing everyone worth knowing.	6
Monk	Studied the ancient arts and honed their body into a weapon.	7
Fighter	Someone paid them to stand in the way, and they never learned to stop.	8
Witch	Had a place in an order once, then something answered.	5

If none fit, work with the GM to create an old life. Use the same Stat array and choose starting gear, maximum Health, and one Perk based on the existing Archetypes.

Pack the gear

Your character has **12 inventory slots**. Put their Archetype gear into the slots from the top down. Worn Armor does not take a slot.

Small things of the same kind bundle together. Three rations, a handful of arrows, or several iron spikes each take one slot.

Step 3: Key goals

Write up to four Key Goals your character wants to achieve. They should matter enough to make the character go out into the world and do something about them.

They can be serious or ridiculous:

- Get revenge on the person who killed their mother.
- Burn down the silly hat shop.
- Find out what happened to their sister.
- Buy back the family house.

Choose goals with a clear end. When your character achieves one, cross it off and gain **2 Luck**.

Share the goals with the other players. Their characters might share one, want to help, or have a very good reason to keep that hat shop standing.

Choose how changed they are

Decide whether the Aether has already changed your character.

Start Unchanged

- Begin with no Mutations and no Spell Tags.
- Their safe casting limit is 3 Exposure.
- Begin with 0 current Exposure, 0 Luck, no Scars, and no Fatigue.

Start Marked

- Roll on the Mutation table and record the result in inventory slot 12.
- Choose one +1 Spell Tag related to the Mutation or the event that made the character an Arcanist.
- Their safe casting limit is 4 Exposure.
- Begin with 0 current Exposure, 0 Luck, no Scars, and no Fatigue.

Starting Marked gives the character more control over magic, but the Aether has already taken one of their twelve slots.

Core Rules

The dice

Say what your character intends to do. **Roll 2d6 plus the fitting stat.** Casting uses one relevant Spell Tag instead.

Roll when the outcome is uncertain and failure would change the situation. Otherwise, let it happen or tell the player what it costs in time or resources.

Total	Result
6 or less	Failure. It goes wrong. Resolve the failure, then gain 1 Luck.
7 to 9	Partial success. Your character does it, but there is a complication.
10 or greater	Full success. Your character achieves what they intended.
Double 1s	Tragic failure.
Double 6s	Critical success.

Check doubles on the two dice that determine the result. Double 1s or double 6s replaces the normal result.

A complication should move events forward. Your character might lose something, end up in danger, attract attention, or get hurt. A partial success still accomplishes what you rolled for.

Luck

Each character can hold up to **10 Luck**.

Gain **1 Luck** after you accept and resolve a failed roll. Gain **2 Luck** when your character achieves a Key Goal and you cross it off their list.

You may give your Luck to another player whenever you like.

Spending Luck

Cost	Buy
1	Add one die to your roll and keep the highest two.
1	Assist another character.
2	Play a flashback that can affect the present.
5	Advance your character.

Add a die

Spend 1 Luck before resolving a roll. Roll **3d6 and keep the highest two**. Only the kept dice count for double 1s or double 6s.

Assist another character

Spend 1 Luck and explain how your character helps. The active player adds 1d6 to their roll and keeps the highest two dice.

If the roll fails, only the active player gains 1 Luck. Everyone who assisted shares the consequences of a failure or partial success.

Flashbacks

Spend 2 Luck to play a short scene from your character's past that affects the present. Maybe they bribed the kitchen servant to leave the back door unlocked.

Play the scene and roll if its outcome is uncertain. Then return to the present with the result. Costs and consequences apply normally. In a turn, the flashback counts as your character's action.

Advancement

Spend 5 Luck to choose one:

- Increase a stat by 1, to a maximum of +3.
- Increase a Spell Tag by 1, to a maximum of +3.
- Increase maximum Health by 1.
- Gain an Archetype Perk.